

The Performed Book

A UNIVERSAL FORMAT FOR THE FUTURE OF READING

68,000 years ago, someone pressed their hand against a cave wall and blew pigment around it — sending a message still being received. Every communication medium since has captured some fraction of the sender's presence and lost the rest. Writing gained permanence but lost the voice. Printing gained reach but lost the hand. Audio recovered the voice but lost the page. The Performed Book puts it all back together.

A recorded vocal performance of a literary text becomes the generative source for living typography, sequential illustration, and acoustic environment — all synchronized to the reader's eye movements. The reader reads, and the book responds. The reader speaks, and the characters answer. The readings of great minds are preserved for future readers. A living web of references surrounds every sentence. Six dials let the reader control everything. The floor is always a book.

SIX CHANNELS

Living Typography

The actor's voice drives variable font parameters — weight, width, slant, spacing, color — so every word carries the presence of the performance. Characters look different because they sound different.

Sequential Illustration

Original artwork recomposed into graphic-novel panel sequences that advance with the reader's gaze. Not animation. Cuts, like turning pages. Tenniel for Carroll, Phiz for Dickens, new commissions for new texts.

Acoustic Environment

A wine pairing, not a soundtrack. Room tone, harmonic atmosphere, and textural response — keyed to the performer's voice and the reader's pace. You never notice it. You just feel Wonderland is deeper than you expected.

Conversational Characters

Press a button, speak to a character. The Caterpillar asks who you are. Humpty Dumpty redefines your words. Your voice appears on the page in your own typographic signature alongside theirs. AI embodiment, constrained by the author's creation.

Curated Readings

The reading traces of notable minds — scholars, artists, leaders, loved ones — preserved as transparent overlays. See where Oprah lingered. Where a dying parent paused. Where your twenty-year-old self raced ahead. The wall accumulates.

Living Reference Web

Four depths of reference activated by attention, not footnotes. Linger on a word and context appears. Go deeper and other texts materialize on the same page in their own typographic voice. Two works touch across centuries, then separate. The web grows forever.

KEY PRINCIPLES

The reader is sovereign

Six dials from zero to full. Voice, typography, illustration, acoustics, curated readings, references. Every dial at zero is a book. No setting is better than another.

THE FORMAT IS UNIVERSAL

It belongs to everyone

Open standard. Public good. Library-funded devices. Free reference webs. The commons of accumulated knowledge cannot be enclosed. The campfire never charged admission.

It knows when to be silent

The deepest reading happens where technology cannot follow — the moment the reader's mind meets the author's mind with nothing between them. The format exists to bring the reader to that threshold and get out of the way.

Any text ever written can become a Performed Book. Carroll, Chaucer, Dickens, Faulkner, Eliot, Homer, the Bhagavad Gita, the Constitution, Darwin's Origin, a journalist's investigation, a parent's letters. Public domain or licensed. Any language — Mandarin tones, Arabic calligraphy, Japanese triple script. Multiple performers per text. Multiple productions. The text is the text. The meta layers vary. The curated readings accumulate across centuries. The reference web grows forever. The entire history of literature is the library.

THE ROAD FROM HERE

Demo — 30 seconds of Alice falling down the rabbit hole. Living typography. Panels cascading. Acoustic space deepening. Toggle to standard. Feel the loss. That moment sells the format.

Launch — Two complete titles. Alice in Wonderland performed by a voice that is an event. One second title in a different register. Full quality. Overwhelming.

Device — Eye-tracking e-reader with GPU and spatial audio. Simultaneously, a tablet app for immediate reach. The experience degrades gracefully. The floor is always a book.

Library — Expand to dozens of titles. Public-domain masterworks funded publicly. Open standard adopted by other manufacturers. Curated readings commissioned.

Commons — Devices in public libraries and schools. Free for everyone. The spectacle subsidizes the infrastructure. Premium content funds universal access.

A hand on a wall, 68,000 years ago, said I exist. The Performed Book says here is a world, and here are all the worlds it touches. The reader reaches back and says I'm here. And in the margins, faintly, other readers say we were here too.